

Glossary

Many plant constituents and their actions are explained in *How Medicinal Plants Work*, pp. 10–16.

Medical

Abortifacient Causes abortion

Adaptogenic Helps the body adapt to stress and supports normal function

Anabolic Promotes tissue growth

Anesthetic Numbs perception of external sensations

Analgesic Reduces pain

Anaphrodisiac Inhibits libido and sexual activity

Anorexia Lack of appetite

Anthelmintic Expels or destroys parasitic worms

Anthraquinones Irritate the intestinal wall causing a bowel movement

Antibiotic Destroys or inhibits microorganisms

Anticoagulant Prevents blood clotting

Antifungal Combats fungal infections

Anti-inflammatory Reduces inflammation

Antimicrobial Destroys or inhibits microorganisms

Antioxidant Prevents oxidation and breakdown of tissues

Antiseptic Destroys or inhibits microorganisms that cause infection

Antispasmodic Relieves muscle spasm, or reduces muscle tone

Antitussive Soothes and relieves coughing

Aperient Mild laxative

Aphrodisiac Excites libido and sexual activity

Aseptic Free from contamination by harmful bacteria, viruses, or other microorganisms

Astringent Tightens mucous membranes and skin, reducing secretions and bleeding from abrasions

Autonomic nervous system Part of the nervous system responsible for the control of bodily functions that are not consciously directed; e.g., sweating, beating of the heart

Ayurveda Traditional Indian system of medicine (see pp. 36–39)

Bitter Stimulates secretions of saliva and digestive juices, increasing appetite

Carcinogenic Causes cancer

Cardiotonic Improves heart function

Carminative Relieves digestive gas and indigestion

Carrier oil Oil such as wheatgerm, to which essential oils are added in order to dilute them for use

Cathartic A drastic purgative

Circulatory stimulant Increases blood flow, usually to a given area; e.g., hands and feet

Colic Abdominal pain produced by strong contractions of intestines or bladder

Compress A cloth pad soaked in a hot or cold herbal extract and applied to the skin

Counterirritant Superficial irritant used to relieve more deep-seated pain or discomfort

Cream A mixture of water and fat or oil that blends with the skin

Decoction Water-based preparation of bark, roots, berries, or seeds simmered in boiling water

Demulcent Coats, soothes, and protects body surfaces such as the gastric mucous membranes

Depurative Detoxifying agent

Detoxification The process of aiding removal of toxins and waste products from the body

Diaphoretic Induces sweating

Diuretic Stimulates urine flow

Doctrine of Signatures Theory that the appearance of a plant reveals its medicinal properties

Eclectic Popular system of herbal medicine in 19th- and early 20th-century North America

Elixir A liquid herbal preparation with a pleasant taste, due to the addition of honey or sugar

Emetic Causes vomiting

Emmenagogue Stimulates menstrual flow

Emollient Softens or soothes the skin

Essential oil Distillation of volatile oils derived from aromatic plants

Expectorant Stimulates coughing and helps clear phlegm from the throat and chest

Febrifuge Reduces fever

Fixed oil A nonvolatile oil (plant constituent). An oil produced by hot or cold infusion (preparation)

Galenical A medicine, in a standard formula, prepared from plants

Hemostatic Stops or reduces bleeding

Hallucinogenic Causes visions or hallucinations

Hepatic Affects the liver

Hepatoprotective Protects the liver

Humor An important body fluid in traditional European or Indian medicine (see p. 32)

Hypertension High blood pressure

Hypnotic Induces sleep

Hypoglycemic Lowers blood glucose levels

Hypotension Low blood pressure

Immune stimulant Stimulates the body's immune defenses to counter infection

Infusion Water-based preparation in which flowers, leaves, or stems are brewed in a similar way to tea

Inhalation Breathing of medicinally infused steam or liquid through the nasal passages

Intermittent fever A fever that recurs regularly; e.g., malaria

Laxative Promotes evacuation of the bowels

Liniment External medication applied by rubbing

Mydriatic Dilates the pupil of the eye

Narcotic Causes drowsiness or stupor and relieves pain

Nervine Restores the nerves; relaxes the nervous system

Neuralgia Pain resulting from irritation or inflammation of a nerve

Edema Fluid retention

Estrogenic With a similar action to estrogen in the body, supporting and maintaining the female reproductive organs

Ointment A blend of fats or oils that form a protective layer over the skin

Oxytocic Induces contractions of the uterus

Parasiticide Kills parasites

Parasympathetic nervous system Part of the nervous system involved in vegetative functions, especially digestion

Pectoral Acts on the lungs

Photosensitive Heightened sensitivity to sunlight

Physiomedicalism 19th- and 20th-century American and British system of herbal medicine

Poultice Herbal preparation usually applied hot to affected area to alleviate pain and reduce swelling

Prostaglandins Chemicals in plants and the human body that have a hormonal action affecting a wide range of conditions including pain and inflammation

Purgative A very strong laxative

Qi Vital energy force in Chinese philosophy (see pp. 24–25)

Rubefacient Stimulates blood flow to skin, causing reddening and warming

Sedative Reduces activity and nervous excitement

Simple An herb used on its own

Spasmolytic Relaxes muscles

Steroids Active chemicals, of animal and plant origin, with powerful hormonal actions

Stimulant Increases rate of activity and nervous excitement

Stomachic Eases stomach pain or increases stomach activity

Styptic Stops bleeding when applied topically

Sympathetic nervous system Part of the nervous system involved in maintaining arousal, alertness, and muscle tone

Systemic Affecting the body as a whole rather than individual organs

Terpenes Molecules that form the base of most constituents of volatile oils

Tincture Plant medicine prepared by macerating herb in water and alcohol

Tonic Exerts a restorative or nourishing action on the body

Tonify Strengthens and restores body systems

Topical Application of herbal remedy to body surface

Vasoconstrictor Contracts and narrows blood vessels

Vasodilator Relaxes and widens blood vessels

Vermifuge Expels intestinal worms

Volatile oil Plant constituent distilled to produce essential oil

Vulnerary Heals wounds

Yin and yang Complementary opposites in Chinese philosophy (see pp. 40–42)

Botanical

Aerial parts Parts of plant growing above ground

Annual Plant that completes its life cycle in a year

Aril Secondary covering over the seed in certain plants

Aromatic Plant with high levels of volatile oil

Axil Upper angle formed by leaf stem and supporting stem or branch

Basal leaves Leaves growing from the base of the stem

Biennial Plant that completes its life cycle in 2 years, generally flowering in the second year

Capsule Dry fruit that splits open when ripe to scatter seeds

Composite flowers Flowers made up of usually 2 types of tiny florets, disc and ray; some have disc florets only

Compound Leaves or flowers made up of many individual small flowers or leaflets

Cordate Having heart-shaped leaves

Corm Bulblike, underground storage organ formed by a swollen stem base

Corolla Collective term for the petals of a flower

Deciduous Plant that sheds leaves each year

Dioecious Species with male and female parts on separate plants

Herbaceous Plant that dies down at the end of the growing season

Insectivorous Plant that traps and digests insects and other small animals

Lanceolate Lance-shaped

Latex Milky fluid found in various plants and trees

Panicle A branched cluster of flowers on stalks in a pyramid-shaped arrangement

Perennial Plant that lives for at least 3 seasons

Pinnate A compound leaf with leaflets growing in 2 rows on each side of its mid-rib

Rhizome Underground storage stem

Stamen Male fertilizing organ of a flowering plant

Stigma Female organ of a flower

Succulent Plant with thick, fleshy leaves and/or stems

Trifoliate Plant with 3 leaves or leaflets

Tuber Thickened part of underground stem

Umbel Umbrella-like arrangement of flowers with all flower stems arising from the same point

Whorl Ring of leaves or flowers radiating out horizontally from a central point

Wildcrafting Harvesting herbs from the wild